

Diversity Statement

As an international female student from China who has lived in the U.S. for nearly 14 years, I intimately understand the challenges faced by international and female students studying abroad. Motivated by my own experiences, I am committed to assisting underrepresented students in overcoming obstacles and enhancing their educational experiences.

Since October 2022, I have volunteered as a peer mentor for the International Student Peer Mentor Program (ISPMP) at UCR. In this role, I supported a first-year international Ph.D. student in adapting to a new culture and environment. Meeting biweekly, we addressed various challenges related to housing, transportation, academics, and social adjustments, aiming to provide comprehensive information and support for a smooth transition. Additionally, I maintain connections with international and minority undergraduate students whom I've taught as a TA or instructor. Offering guidance on graduate school applications, editing CVs and personal statements, and writing recommendation letters are ways I've assisted them beyond the classroom. As a PhD graduate in Economics, I actively provide advice to current international graduate students on course selection, field specialization, and preparation for qualification exams.

In my role as the Instructor of Intermediate Microeconomics Theory (ECON102) in the summer of 2022, I actively promoted diversity in the classroom. I focused on creating an inclusive environment where every student felt comfortable participating. Choosing discussion topics that appealed to a broad audience, offering assistance regardless of background, and valuing the diversity each student brought were integral to my teaching philosophy. For instance, I aided a minority student struggling to merge scanned documents into one file on a computer by patiently providing various methods and demonstrating the necessary steps. I firmly believe that offering help to underrepresented students facing difficulties is essential for their success.

My role as a Graduate Student Researcher (GSR) at the Inland Empire Labor and Community Center (IELCC) allowed me to contribute to projects addressing inequality in the local region. Specifically, my work on "The State of Work in the Inland Empire Part II: Pandemic, Polarization, Inflation, and Investment (November 2023)" shed light on disparities in working conditions and opportunities. I produced informative graphs comparing demographics, education, employment, transportation, poverty, earnings, inequality, and housing in the Inland Empire (IE) with other regions, highlighting disparities among different ethnic groups. For example, we found lower real labor earnings and higher poverty rates among Latinos, non-Latino Black individuals, and Native Americans, along with a notable gap between rising rent costs and earnings growth in the IE. This experience underscored the importance of improving educational and training opportunities to support the Inland Empire's transition towards a more equitable and sustainable future.

Thriving in diverse academic environments, I am passionate about supporting the academic success of students from various backgrounds. I am dedicated to helping all students succeed. My belief in the significance of a supportive and diverse community for academic success drives my commitment to contributing to and building strong connections within the community.